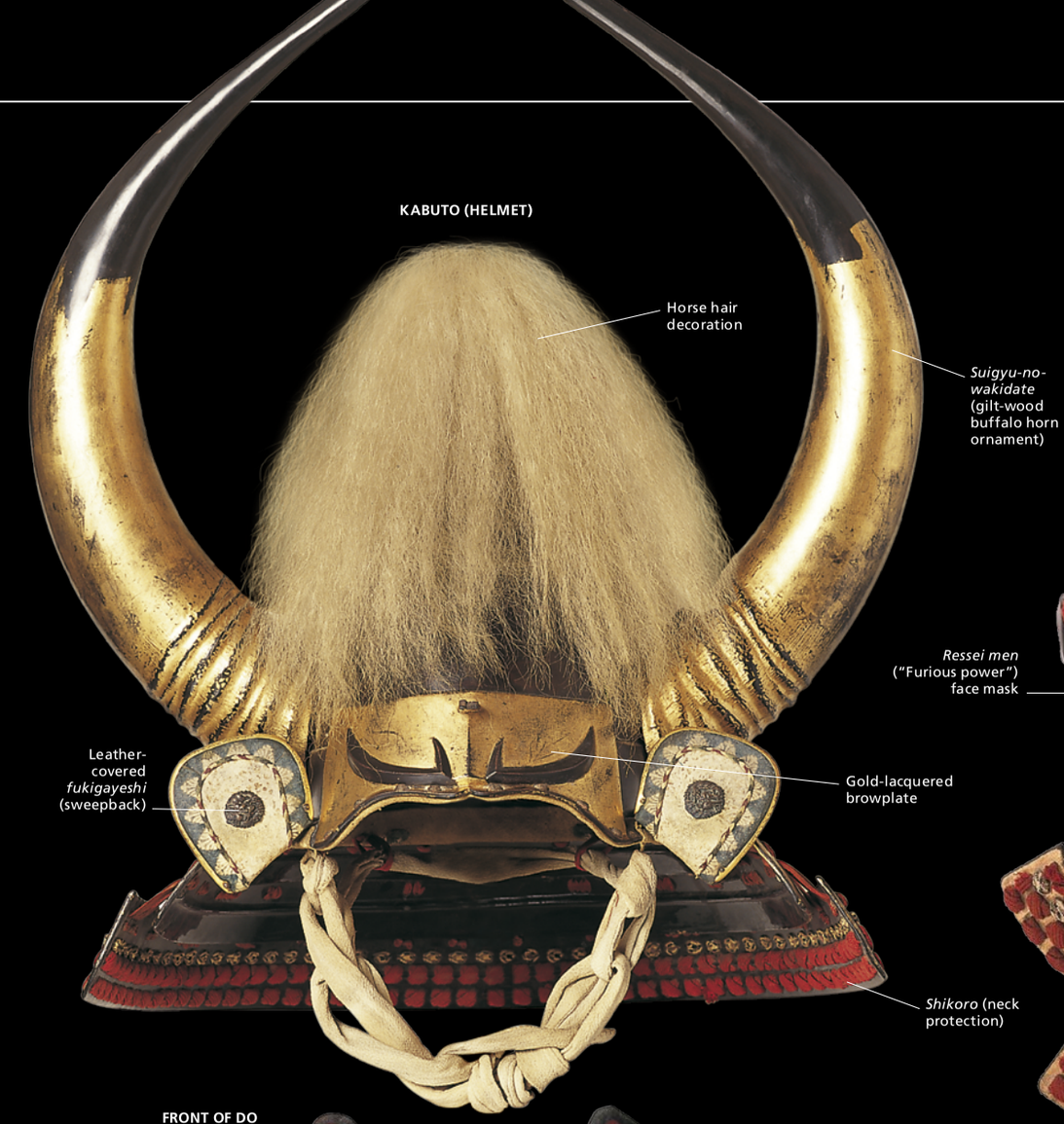
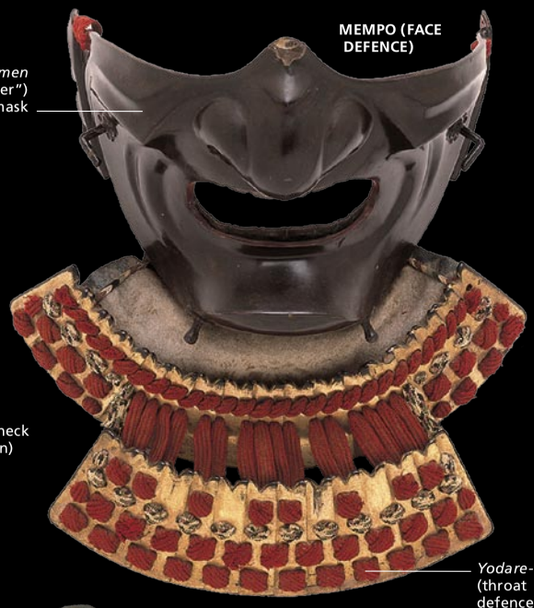
SAMURAI ARMOUR

The design of Japanese samurai armour centred on two principal functions – to be strong enough to provide adequate protection in battle, and light and flexible enough to permit the free movement needed by a sword-fighter. The style of armour, which has its roots in the Asiatic tradition of *lamellar* (scaled) armour, consists of lacquered plates of metal or leather bound together by silk or leather lacing. This reached a heightened level of sophistication in the *tosei gusoku* (modern armour) style from the 16th century onwards, the focus eventually shifting towards decoration.





Helmet and face defence
The samurai helmet *(far left)* features *wakidate*, or side crests, made from imitation buffalo-horn (antlers were also popular as *wakidate*). The black-lacquered half-mask, or *mempo (left)*, served three purposes – it provided good protection for the samurai's lower face, helped hold the helmet on the warrior's head, and made the wearer look intimidating, especially when (as was often the case) eyebrows were embossed on the browplate. This example is missing a moustache.

